

60 WINDS OF CHANGE revolutions

GITA PRESS

Holy WORD

Much before *Ramayana* was a gleam in Ramanand Sagar's eyes, a tiny printing press made Hindu scriptures part of the middle class Indian's everyday life

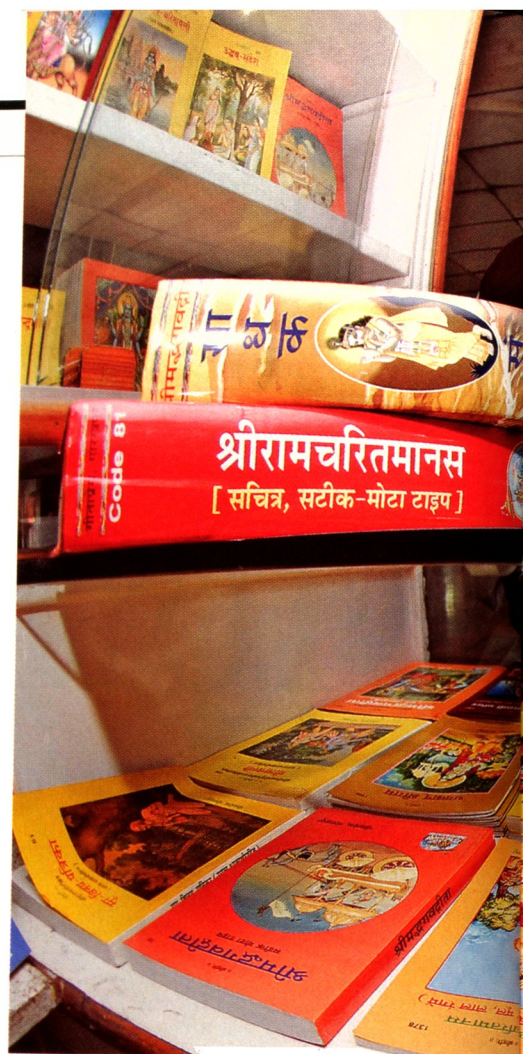
■ By Sheokesh Mishra

In Gorakhpur's bustling Hindi Bazaar, the printing press is working overtime—churning out Hindu spiritual literature from the *Mahabharata* and the *Puranas* to *Badon Ke Jeevan Se Shiksha*, a 96-page book for children. This is Gita Press, one of the most authentic sources of ancient scriptures in modern India. The entrance to the press is an impressive blend of Indian temple architecture—while the pillars are inspired from the cave temples of Ellora, the gopuram is influenced by the Meenakshi temple in Madurai. Inside, as the 145 employees go about their job, editing and proof-reading, a man goes from table to table, room to room. He mutters “*Narayana-narayana*” very much like the mythological Narad Muni, to the people working there, perhaps as a spiritual incentive. And he does this four times a day, every day.

Set up over nine decades ago, the Press has published 6.34 crore copies of the *Gita* (in different editions) and 6.49 crore copies of the *Ramcharitamanas*. Despite the large quantities that it prints, it is unable to meet the demand from readers. In 2006, it consumed 3,600-tonne of paper and had a sale of Rs 25 crore, while in the first seven months of this year the paper consumption was 2,237 tonne. It is believed that the *Akhand Paath* (recitation of the *Ramcharitamanas* in 24 hours) became popular only after the press published it in the form of a special issue as part of its monthly magazine *Kalyan*. The magazine, started in 1927, be-

SWAMI PRABHUPADA, founder, ISKCON, 1976

“No other religion has such a full concept of God. God has a name, and his name is Krishna.”



came a major platform to promote moral values. It started with a circulation of 1,600 copies and its latest print order was 2.3 lakh. But the magazine is famous for its special issues which are sought after because of the publication of original Hindu scriptures along with a Hindi translation. The *Puranas* like Garun, Koorm, Waman and Vishnu were translated for the first time and circulated via the magazine.

Its popularity spans the entire country. For example, Anand Swami, 70, of Mochi Sai in Puri, Orissa, has waited patiently for the *Bhagvad Gita*. He says there are readers who come all the way from Kalahandi, one of the poorest districts in the state, to buy the *Jagannathi Bhagwat*, also published by the Press. “I’m old, but the bold letters make it easy to read. Also, books are rather inexpensive. You can purchase 12 Upanishads for the value of 10 kg wheat,” he says. In fact, the cheapest book given out by the Press costs a mere Re 1 while the costliest is the six-volume *Mahabharata* that costs Rs 1,350.

Hindi critic Parmanand Srivastava says Gita Press has been responsible for evolving a completely new book culture in the world. “You can find its stalls in Puducherry too. It has a wide presence,” he says. The